

THE SHELTER

SYNOPSIS

Hatice and her six-month-old baby Nilüfer are hiding in a shelter. As Hatice struggles with the psychological toll of desperation during this period of isolation, she is forced to make impossible decisions for her daughter and for herself. The only news of the war above comes from the radio, which keeps repeating the same promise of hope; by the time rescue finally arrives, the price Hatice has paid can no longer be taken back.

TREATMENT

SEQUENCE 1 — THE PHOTOGRAPH

The shelter: concrete walls, a single air vent near the ceiling, one gas lamp. The power is out. A water canister stands in one corner, a few tins on a shelf, a chessboard and an unframed photograph on the table. Muffled explosions sound far in the distance.

Hatice sits in an armchair in the shelter. She watches her baby Nilüfer rocking in the cradle. Nilüfer begins to cry. Hatice rises, goes to Nilüfer and takes her in her arms. She tries to soothe Nilüfer and talks to the baby. She says hopeful things: that her father is coming, that they will all go home together. The baby settles. She puts the baby back in the cradle.

She moves toward the table. She looks at the photograph lying on it: three smiling people — Hatice with Nilüfer in her arms, Kemal beside her — a sunny, familiar garden behind them. She lingers on the happiness in the photograph for a moment. She picks up the knife. There are notches along the edge of the table, few enough to be counted. She cuts one more — the sound of the blade against the wood carries over into the flashback.

[FLASHBACK — The day the photograph was taken] The photograph comes alive. Hatice is at the time and place where the photograph was taken: a sunny day, the war still only a distant possibility. She is talking with Kemal. They tell each other about their dreams and about how peaceful their life is. Nilüfer is in her arms. Hatice is very happy.

SEQUENCE 2 — THE RADIO

Hatice wakes to Nilüfer crying. She goes to the baby to calm her. As Hatice holds and soothes the baby, sound comes from the radio. The voice on the radio says the war is going well and that people need to hold out only a little longer. It states that victory will come very soon and that the army will come to rescue them.

Hatice sets the baby down. She looks at the tins on the shelf. Very few are left. She lifts the water canister and weighs it in her hand; it is half empty. Hatice talks to Nilüfer. She says how much time they have left and that she hopes the tins will be enough. She caresses Nilüfer.

She sits down on the chair in front of the table. She looks at the photograph and the chessboard lying on it. She picks up the chess pieces and plays with them. She takes the knife and cuts one more notch.

[FLASHBACK — Chess] Hatice is playing chess with Kemal. She asks her husband why he needs a shelter at all. She says that wars can no longer break out in this day and age and that her husband is being paranoid. They laugh together. Kemal lifts the pawn he's holding. He starts to say that the king looks like the most valuable piece on the board, but the pawns actually matter more — before he finishes the thought, Hatice's laughter cuts him off, and they laugh together, changing the subject. He says there is no harm in taking precautions.

SEQUENCE 3 — THE LAST TIN

Hatice waits by the radio while she eats from the last remaining tin. She rocks anxiously in her chair. The number of notches on the table has grown; they now run the length of the table's edge. The distant explosions have thinned out — it is unclear whether the war is over.

Nilüfer begins to cry. Hatice looks at the empty tins. She goes to Nilüfer and takes her in her arms. She tries to nurse Nilüfer. Nilüfer latches on and falls quiet.

Meanwhile, sound comes from the radio. It is the same recording as a few days ago, repeating: the same crackle, the same sentence skipping at the same point. Hatice mutters the words from the radio back, hopelessly, then begins to cry. She holds Nilüfer tightly. She says they have to hold out a little longer. She puts Nilüfer back in the cradle. Hatice looks for a long while at Nilüfer lying there. She goes to the table. She picks up the knife and cuts one more notch.

[FLASHBACK — Called up] Hatice is lying in bed with Kemal. There is a hard knock at the door. Kemal goes to open it. After a while he comes back. He says he has been called up, that she must look after herself, and that she must protect Nilüfer no matter what. He guarantees that things will not go badly, but tells her that if they do, she must get into the shelter and never come out until he comes for them, that there is enough food down there and that they will be safe. Hatice does not know what to say. She holds her husband; she asks him to take care of himself and to keep his promise and come back. Kemal promises.

SEQUENCE 4 — MILK

Hatice is startled awake by Nilüfer's crying. She is in a wretched state: her hair is matted, her lips cracked, she is wearing the same clothes she has had on for days. She goes to Nilüfer and tries to quiet her, but cannot. She laments that she has no milk left and begs Nilüfer to be quiet. Nilüfer's screams echo through the shelter, mixing with Hatice's sobbing.

Nilüfer cries herself into exhaustion and falls asleep. Hatice puts Nilüfer down in the cradle and moves to the table. There she goes on crying quietly. She picks up the white king from the chessboard and closes her fist around it. She says she knows he is coming, that he has always kept his word, and tries to comfort herself. She sets the king carefully back on the board, in its starting square. She picks up the knife and cuts one more notch.

SEQUENCE 5 — THE HATCH

Hatice paces inside the shelter. Nilüfer's crying grows much worse. Hatice approaches Nilüfer in a fury. She begs her to be quiet. But she cannot bring herself to harm Nilüfer.

She storms to the shelter hatch and throws her full weight against it; it gives a few centimeters, then stops against some weight piled on top of it from outside. Dust and ash pour in through the gap. Hatice pounds on the hatch and shouts; no answer comes. In her rage she hurls the chair to the floor. She sprains her wrist.

Meanwhile, the announcement from a few days ago repeats on the radio. This time Hatice grabs the radio and throws it against the wall. Only one sound is left in the shelter now: Nilüfer's crying. Hatice goes to the bed and pulls the blanket over her head. She begins to cry. She apologizes to Nilüfer.

SEQUENCE 6 — THE KNIFE

Hatice is utterly spent. She has collapsed from hunger. She can barely move. The wick of the gas lamp has burned low; the shelter is darker than before. No more crying comes from Nilüfer. She goes to the cradle and checks whether Nilüfer is alive. Nilüfer is alive.

She starts talking to Nilüfer, pouring her heart out. She says she has no hope left, that she cannot bear watching Nilüfer and herself die slowly. She speaks of her anger at her husband for not keeping his promise, and says that she is finished.

Hatice moves toward the table and picks up the knife. She approaches Nilüfer quickly. Hatice looks at the sleeping Nilüfer, her eyes welling up. Hatice's hand is shaking.

*[FLASHBACK — A single line] Kemal's voice returns out of the dark as one sentence:
"Protect Nilüfer no matter what."*

As she brings the knife toward Nilüfer she begins to cry and decides that she cannot do it. She sinks to her knees; the knife is still in her hand.

SEQUENCE 7 — THE RESCUE

Suddenly, heavy blows land on the shelter hatch; the rubble outside is being shoveled away. Hatice looks toward the hatch with hope and tries to call out, but her voice comes out too faint. As she struggles to her feet, she forgets to let go of the knife.

The hatch opens. The daylight striking down from above blinds Hatice; she cannot see who is in front of her. A man's voice shouts from outside, "She's got a knife!" and a rifle shot is heard. Nilüfer begins to cry. Hatice collapses to the floor.

A female and a male soldier come inside. The soldiers look first at Hatice, then at the baby. The woman starts shouting angrily at the man; she speaks of his rawness, of the fact that he has killed an innocent and will answer for it, that what he has done is unforgivable, and that there is a baby down here. The man is overcome with remorse for his mistake. Not knowing what to do, he leans back against the wall and takes his head in his hands.

Hatice's eyes are slowly opening and closing. Sounds begin to reach her muffled. The frame narrows; from now on we see only what Hatice sees. Inside, off frame, another gunshot is heard. The woman has picked Nilüfer up and come to Hatice's side. Hatice cannot see the man.

The woman tells Hatice that she cannot save her, but that she can at least keep her daughter alive, and asks for the girl's name. Hatice answers in a whisper: "Nilüfer." The woman, her eyes brimming, apologizes. Hatice is saying thank you when her breath gives out and she dies.

As the female soldier carries the baby up and out, she knocks into the table. The chess pieces topple: the white king falls to the floor, and the only piece left standing is a pawn. The hatch stays open. The notches along the edge of the table stand out, one by one, in the daylight falling across them.